

High-Growth in Northern Ireland

Mapping out the most ambitious
businesses in Northern Ireland

What do we mean by “high-growth and “ambitious”?

We use 8 criteria to identify high-growth and ambitious companies. Each of these is a sign of external validation that a business is either actively growing or creating ambitious growth plans.

All companies featured in this report have met at least one of these growth triggers.



Equity investment



Venture debt



Accelerator attendance



Grant recipients



Scaleups



High-growth lists



MBO/MBI



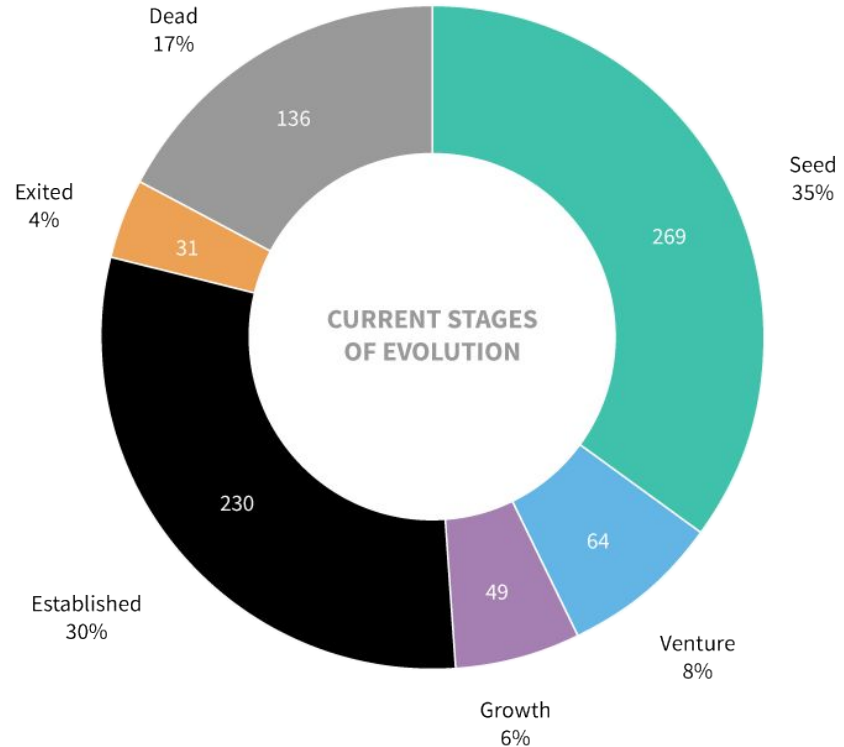
Academic spinouts

Stages of evolution

There are **612** active, ambitious companies in Northern Ireland.

An additional **31** have exited the market, either through an IPO or an acquisition, and **136** are no longer trading.

The region has a strong base of established businesses. The seed stage is the most populated, with few companies having developed into the venture and growth stages of evolution.



Methods of growth

Only **32%** of high-growth companies in Northern Ireland have raised equity investment, far lower than the national average of 52%.

Instead, it has a very healthy population of scaleups: **32%** of high-growth companies have achieved at least 10% scaleup status.

The most common method of growth is attending an accelerator, the most popular of which was the now inactive Entrepreneurial Spark, powered by Ulster Bank Hatchery.

Raised equity

246

**Attended
accelerators**

290

**Received a large
innovation grant**

117

**Spun out of a
university**

54

**Visibly reached 10%
scaleup status**

249

**Visibly reached
20% scaleup status**

202

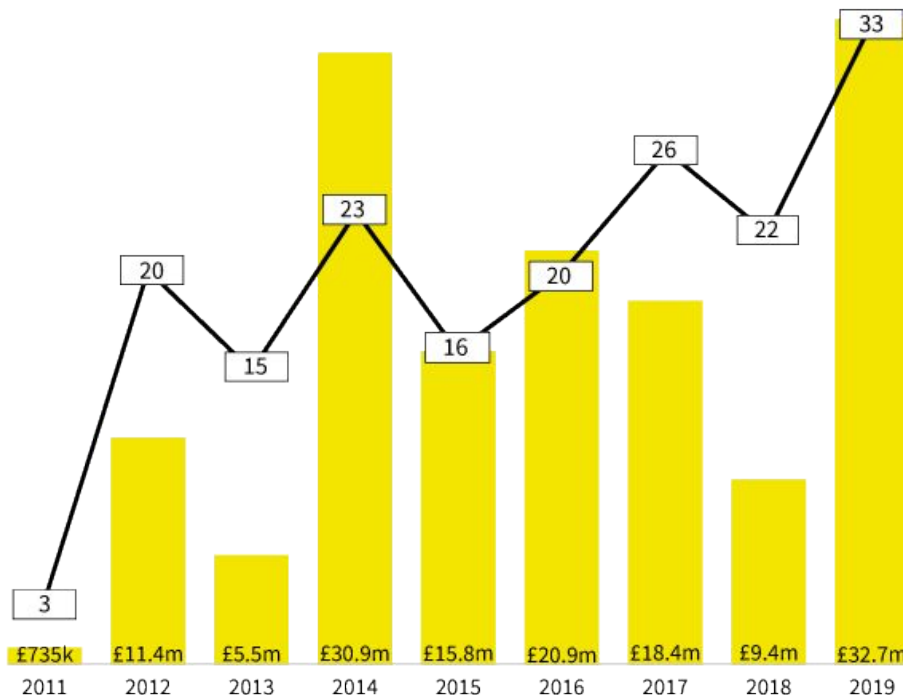
Fundraising statistics

£145m of equity investment has been deployed across **178** announced deals since 2011.

A total of 246 companies in Northern Ireland have raised equity investment, 100 of which have never announced their fundraisings to the media.

2019 was a record year for Northern Ireland's high-growth businesses, with more pounds invested over more deals than any year prior.

NUMBER OF ANNOUNCED DEALS AND AMOUNT RAISED

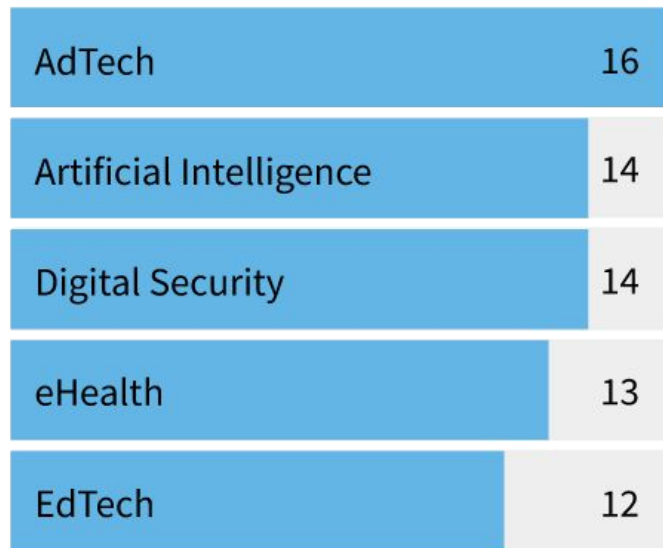


Sectors and verticals

AdTech is the most common buzzword in Northern Ireland. This includes **Péarlaí**, which develops a software that allows shopping centres and retailers to track individual customers through physical stores, predict their buying behaviours, and send personalised offers to their phones.

AI and Digital Security are also fairly strong areas, with 14 companies operating within each.

NUMBER OF AMBITIOUS COMPANIES IN NORTHERN IRELAND

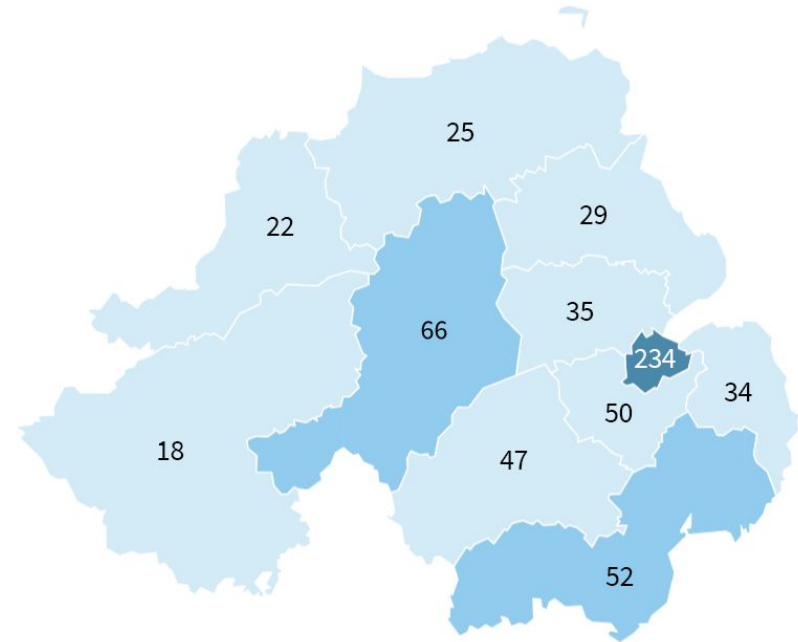


Geographical distribution

Unsurprisingly, Belfast is the most saturated area of high-growth companies, with **234** active ambitious companies operating in the city. Belfast is home to a far higher proportion of seed stage companies (45%) compared to the rest of the country (26%), as well as a higher proportion of dead companies (21% vs 16%). This suggests that the capital is an incubator for the country's riskiest ventures.

Mid Ulster and Newry, Mourne and Down are the next most densely populated, whilst the West of the country is home to the fewest high-growth firms.

DISTRIBUTION OF ACTIVE AMBITIOUS COMPANIES

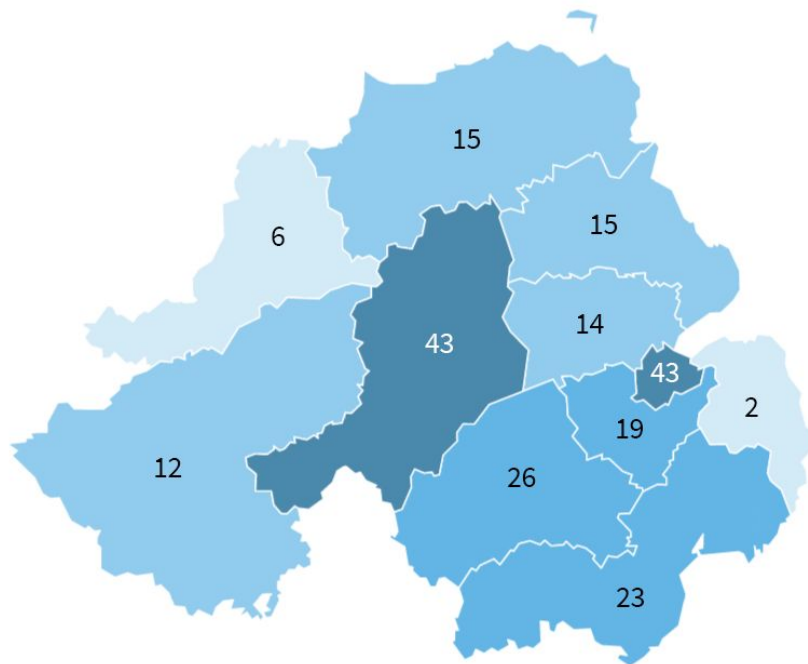


Scaleups

The country's scaleups show a slightly more even geographical distribution. Mid Ulster ties with Belfast as the most densely populated district, each home to 43 visibly scaling businesses.

More than half of scaleups in Mid Ulster operate within the industrial sector, primarily manufacturing building materials, furniture and machinery. In Belfast, the majority of scaleups are operating within the business and professional services sector, particularly in insurance, security and financial services.

DISTRIBUTION OF 10% AND 20% SCALEUP COMPANIES



Female founders

31% of high-growth companies in Northern Ireland have a female founder, the second highest rate in the UK, after Scotland.

82% of female founded businesses are in the seed stage of evolution, representing a strong pipeline of investable companies for the future. It remains to be seen if these businesses receive sufficient funding to progress through the next stages of evolution.

MOST FUNDED FEMALE FOUNDED BUSINESSES

AUDITCOMPLY

LOCATION

Belfast

STAGE OF EVOLUTION

Seed

FUNDRAISINGS SECURED

£4.47m over 3 rounds

FOUNDED BY

Susan Fitzsimmons, Kevin Donaghy, Patrick Keehan



KRAYDEL

LOCATION

Belfast

STAGE OF EVOLUTION

Venture

FUNDRAISINGS SECURED

£2.83m over 6 rounds

FOUNDED BY

Lisa Smith, Amer Fasihi, Rupinder Singh, Paul Moorhead

Kraydel

Top companies by total amount of funding raised



Devenish produces animal feed developed for the intensive livestock farming industry.

Location

Belfast

Stage of evolution

Established

Total amount of equity raised

£106m

Number of rounds completed

1



seven technologies group

Seven Technologies designs and engineers intelligence systems for use in inhospitable environments.

Location

Lisburn

Stage of evolution

Growth

Total amount of equity raised

£12m

Number of rounds completed

4



WJ Law is a designer and builder of houses, especially in the "country Georgian" style.

Location

Lisburn

Stage of evolution

Established

Total amount raised

£10m

Number of rounds completed

1

Top companies by growth in turnover (2018-2019)



ASEE provides mechanical and electrical engineering services, for businesses.

Location

Newry, Mourne and Down

Stage of evolution

Established

Reported turnover in 2019

£35.9m

Growth from 2018

104%



Skurio provides intelligence and risk assessment services through social media monitoring.

Location

Belfast

Stage of evolution

Venture

Reported turnover in 2019

£536k

Growth from 2018

83%



Woodland manufactures custom furniture for kitchens, bedrooms and bathrooms.

Location

Causeway Coast and Glens

Stage of evolution

Established

Reported turnover in 2019

£19.6m

Growth from 2018

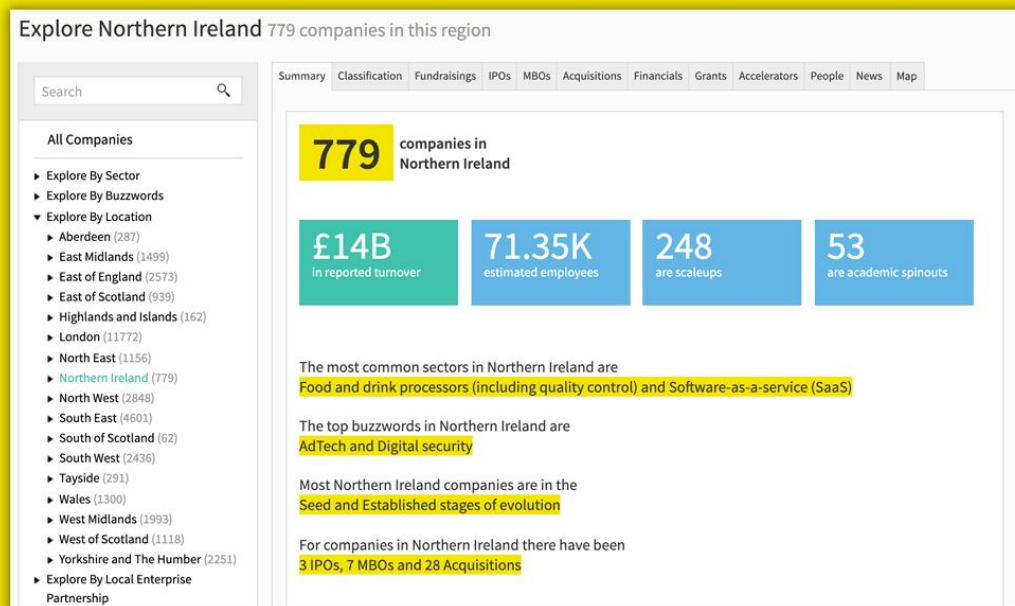
66%

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